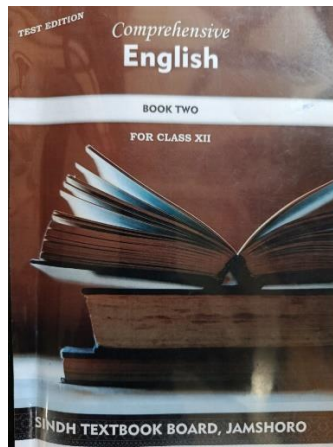


For the Class-XII



I HAVE A DREAM

By

JR. MARTIN LUTHER KING



About the Orator

Name	Jr. Martin Luther King
Born & died	January 15, 1929
Place of birth	April 4, 1968
Profession	Baptist minister and a civil rights activist
Notable works	Delivery of the “I Have a Dream” speech, the 1965 Selma to Montgomery marches, and his 1964 Nobel Peace Prize win

Q1- How does Martin Luther King describe the current conditions of Africans, despite the promises made a century earlier?

Ans- Martin Luther King Jr. describes that even after a hundred years of the Emancipation Proclamation, African Americans still suffer from injustice. They are bound by segregation and discrimination, living in poverty surrounded by material wealth. They remain excluded and marginalized in their own country, unable to fully enjoy the promised rights of life, liberty, and happiness. Many are trapped in ghettos, denied dignity, voting rights, and equal opportunities. He emphasizes that these unfulfilled promises create a “shameful condition” that must be addressed without delay.

Q2- What does Martin Luther King mean he says, “Now is the time to rise from the dark and desolated valley of segregation to the sunlit path of a racial justice?”

Ans- By saying this, Martin Luther King Jr. means that it is the moment to end the unfair system of segregation and replace it with equality and fairness for all races. The “dark and desolate valley” represents the pain, isolation, and injustice caused by racial separation. The “sunlit path of racial justice” symbolizes a future of hope, unity, and equal rights. He urges immediate action to move

from discrimination and inequality toward a society where justice and brotherhood guide relationships among all people.

Q3- Why does Martin Luther King emphasize that the struggle for equality must be conducted with dignity and discipline?

Ans- Martin Luther King Jr. emphasizes that the struggle for equality must be carried out with dignity and discipline to prevent it from turning into violence. He believes protests should remain creative and peaceful, rising to the “majestic heights” of meeting physical force with moral strength, or “soul force.” Violence, he warns, would harm the cause and create division. By acting with respect and self-control, the movement can inspire unity, gain moral authority, and show that the fight is for justice and brotherhood, not revenge or hatred.

Q4- How does the phrase “Justice rolls down like the waters” deepen the emotional impact of the speech?

Ans- The phrase “Justice rolls down like the waters” adds strong emotional power to the speech by painting a clear picture of justice as a powerful, unstoppable force, like a mighty river. It suggests that true justice should flow naturally, cleansing society of oppression and inequality. This biblical image stirs hope, faith, and moral urgency in the audience, reminding them that justice is both a divine promise and a human responsibility. It inspires listeners to believe that fairness will eventually prevail across the nation.

Q5- What message does Martin Luther King convey to his listeners through his speech?

Ans- Martin Luther King Jr. conveys a message of hope, unity, and urgent action for equality. He urges America to fulfill its promise that all people are created equal, regardless of race. He dreams of a future where people are judged by character, not skin color, and where former enemies live as brothers. He calls for peaceful, dignified struggle to end segregation, discrimination, and injustice. His message inspires faith that freedom and justice will prevail, and that together, people can build a nation based on equality and brotherhood.

Q6- What roll does hope play in Martin Luther King’s speech, and how does it influence the audience’s response?

Ans- In Martin Luther King Jr.’s speech, hope acts as a guiding light that keeps the struggle for equality alive despite present hardships. He speaks of faith that justice will come and that unity will replace division. This hope motivates the audience to believe change is possible and worth fighting for. By sharing his dream of a fair and equal America, he inspires listeners to remain strong, patient, and committed, turning despair into determination and encouraging them to work together for lasting freedom and justice.

Q7- How does Martin Luther King use contrast between past injustices and future hopes to strengthen his argument?

Ans- Martin Luther King Jr. strengthens his argument by showing the sharp difference between the painful past and his hopeful vision of the future. He recalls centuries of slavery, segregation, and discrimination that have denied African Americans their rights. Against this, he presents a dream of equality, unity, and justice where all races live together in harmony. This contrast makes the injustice of the present more striking and the hope for change more inspiring, urging the audience to act now to turn that dream into reality.

Meanings and Synonyms of Difficult Words and Phrases (Glossary) from the Speech “I Have a Dream” to Ease Learners’ Understanding



1. **Captivity** – The state of being kept as a prisoner or confined.
Synonyms: imprisonment, confinement, detention
2. **Crippled** – Severely damaged or weakened; unable to function properly.
Synonyms: disabled, impaired, weakened
3. **Crooked places** – Areas or situations that are bent, twisted, or morally wrong.
Synonyms: bent, deformed, dishonest
4. **Decree** – An official order or decision made by a ruler or authority.
Synonyms: order, command, proclamation
5. **Degenerate** – To decline in quality, morals, or character.
Synonyms: deteriorate, worsen, decay
6. **Desolate** – Empty, bleak, and without hope or comfort.
Synonyms: barren, bleak, deserted

7. **Despair** – A complete loss of hope.
Synonyms: hopelessness, discouragement, gloom
8. **Destiny** – The events that are believed to happen inevitably in the future.
Synonyms: fate, fortune, future
9. **Discord** – Disagreement, conflict, or lack of harmony.
Synonyms: conflict, disharmony, dispute
10. **Discrimination** – Unfair treatment based on race, gender, religion, etc.
Synonyms: prejudice, bias, unfairness
11. **Distrust** – Lack of trust; suspicion.
Synonyms: suspicion, doubt, mistrust
12. **Dramatize** – To present or express something in a vivid or striking way.
Synonyms: exaggerate, highlight, emphasize
13. **Emphasize** – To give special importance to something.
Synonyms: stress, underline, accentuate
14. **Engulfed** – Completely surrounded or overwhelmed.
Synonyms: swallowed, submerged, overwhelmed
15. **Exalted** – Raised in status, rank, or praise; highly honored.
Synonyms: elevated, glorified, honored
16. **Exile** – Being forced to live away from one's home or country.
Synonyms: banishment, expulsion, deportation
17. **Ghetto** – A poor, often crowded area where a minority group lives.
Synonyms: slum, rundown district, impoverished area
18. **Hamlet** – A small village.
Synonyms: village, settlement, community
19. **Hew** – To cut or shape something, especially with an axe.
Synonyms: chop, carve, cut
20. **Inextricably** – In a way that is impossible to separate.
Synonyms: inseparably, indivisibly, permanently
21. **Interposition** – The act of placing something between two parties.
Synonyms: intervention, mediation, interference
22. **Jangling** – Producing a harsh, unpleasant sound; also used for disorder.
Synonyms: clanging, clattering, rattling

23. Languished – To become weak or suffer due to neglect or hardship.
Synonyms: weakened, declined, deteriorated
24. Majestic heights – Great and impressive achievements or standards.
Synonyms: grand achievements, noble standards, lofty goals
25. Manacles – Metal chains or restraints for the hands or feet.
Synonyms: shackles, handcuffs, restraints
26. Marvellous – Wonderful or extraordinary.
Synonyms: wonderful, amazing, splendid
27. Material prosperity – Wealth and success in terms of possessions and money.
Synonyms: affluence, wealth, economic success
28. Midst – In the middle of something.
Synonyms: middle, center, midst
29. Militancy – Aggressive or active support for a cause.
Synonyms: activism, aggressiveness, combativeness
30. Mobility – The ability to move freely or easily.
Synonyms: movement, flexibility, motion
31. Molehill – A small mound of earth made by a mole; figuratively, a small problem.
Synonyms: mound, bump, trifle
32. Momentous – Very important or significant.
Synonyms: significant, important, historic
33. Nullification – The act of making something legally void or ineffective.
Synonyms: cancellation, annulment, invalidation
34. Oppression – Prolonged cruel or unfair treatment.
Synonyms: persecution, injustice, tyranny
35. Pilgrim – A traveler, especially one on a journey for religious purposes.
Synonyms: traveler, worshipper, wayfarer
36. Pledge – A serious promise or commitment.
Synonyms: promise, vow, oath
37. Prodigious – Remarkably large or impressive.
Synonyms: enormous, huge, extraordinary
38. Pursuit – The act of chasing or striving for something.
Synonyms: chase, quest, search

39. **Racial** – Related to race or ethnicity.
Synonyms: ethnic, cultural, ethnological
40. **Righteousness** – Morally right behavior.
Synonyms: virtue, morality, integrity
41. **Seared** – Burned or scorched on the surface.
Synonyms: burned, singed, charred
42. **Segregation** – The separation of people based on race or other factors.
Synonyms: separation, division, apartheid
43. **Self-evident** – Obvious without needing explanation.
Synonyms: obvious, clear, apparent
44. **Self-hood** – The quality that makes one's identity unique.
Synonyms: individuality, identity, personality
45. **Sweltering** – Extremely hot and uncomfortable.
Synonyms: boiling, scorching, blazing
46. **Symphony** – A long and complex piece of music for an orchestra; harmony of different parts.
Synonyms: harmony, composition, orchestration
47. **Take place** – To happen or occur.
Synonyms: occur, happen, transpire
48. **Unalienable** – Unable to be taken away or transferred.
Synonyms: inherent, absolute, inviolable
49. **Withering** – Drying up or weakening; often used for harsh criticism or decline.
Synonyms: wilting, fading, decaying

A set of 15 MCQs based directly on the historic speech “I Have a Dream” to help learners better understand the text.



1. Where did Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. deliver his “I Have a Dream” speech?
 - A) The White House Lawn
 - B) Lincoln Memorial
 - C) United Nations Headquarters
 - D) Jefferson Memorial
2. Approximately how many people attended the speech?
 - A) 150,000
 - B) 200,000
 - C) 250,000
 - D) 300,000
3. What was one of the main purposes of the speech?
 - A) To promote new economic policies
 - B) To end racism and segregation
 - C) To encourage immigration
 - D) To announce a political candidacy
4. What historical document does King refer to when speaking about “unalienable Rights”?
 - A) The Bill of Rights
 - B) The Declaration of Independence
 - C) The Emancipation Proclamation
 - D) The Constitution’s Preamble
5. In the speech, “the dark and desolate valley” symbolizes:
 - A) Peaceful protest
 - B) Economic growth
 - C) Racial segregation
 - D) Political unity

- 6.** What does King describe as the “sunlit path”?
- A) Financial freedom
 - B) Political reform
 - C) Racial justice
 - D) Technological progress
- 7.** How does King say the struggle for equality should be conducted?
- A) With force and urgency
 - B) With dignity and discipline
 - C) Through political lobbying only
 - D) By avoiding public demonstrations
- 8.** According to the speech, what should protests avoid?
- A) Creative ideas
 - B) Physical violence
 - C) Political engagement
 - D) Emotional appeal
- 9.** King warns against distrusting:
- A) All government officials
 - B) All white people
 - C) The justice system
 - D) The education system
- 10.** What phrase does King use to describe the unstoppable nature of justice?
- A) “Justice stands tall”
 - B) “Justice rolls down like the waters”
 - C) “Justice will shine like the sun”
 - D) “Justice flows from the mountains”
- 11.** What dream does King have for his four children?
- A) To become political leaders
 - B) To live in a nation judged by character, not skin color
 - C) To live in a racially separate but equal society
 - D) To study in foreign countries
- 12.** In the dream, former slaves and slave owners’ sons will:
- A) Compete in elections
 - B) Sit together at the table of brotherhood
 - C) Own businesses together
 - D) Join the same political party
- 13.** Which U.S. state does King describe as “sweltering with the heat of injustice”?
- A) Alabama

- B) Mississippi
- C) Georgia
- D) South Carolina

14. King envisions “little black boys and little black girls” in Alabama:

- A) Playing sports together
- B) Attending the same schools
- C) Joining hands with little white boys and girls as sisters and brothers
- D) Singing together in church

15. What song does King reference near the end of the speech?

- A) America the Beautiful
- B) My Country, 'Tis of Thee
- C) The Star-Spangled Banner
- D) This Land Is Your Land

Answer key with justification:

1. B – Lincoln Memorial

The speech was delivered at the Lincoln Memorial in Washington, D.C.

2. C – 250,000

The text mentions King addressed over 250,000 people.

3. B – To end racism and segregation

The speech’s central purpose was to call for an end to racism, segregation, and injustice.

4. B – The Declaration of Independence

King quotes the Declaration’s promise of “unalienable Rights” — life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.

5. C – Racial segregation

The “dark and desolate valley” metaphor refers to the hardships caused by segregation.

6. C – Racial justice

The “sunlit path” symbolizes racial justice and equality.

7. B – With dignity and discipline

King stressed the need for peaceful, disciplined protests, avoiding violence.

8. B – Physical violence

He urged that creative protests must not degenerate into physical violence.

9. B – All white people

King said the struggle should not lead to distrust of all white people, as many supported equality.

10. B – “Justice rolls down like the waters”

This vivid image shows justice as a powerful and unstoppable force.

11. B – To live in a nation judged by character, not skin color

King dreams of a society where his children are judged by their character.

12. B – Sit together at the table of brotherhood

He envisions reconciliation between descendants of slaves and slave owners.

13. B – Mississippi

Mississippi is described as “sweltering with the heat of injustice” and oppression.

14. C – Joining hands with little white boys and girls as sisters and brothers

In Alabama, he dreams of children of all races uniting as equals.

15. B – My Country, 'Tis of Thee

King quotes lines from the patriotic song “My Country, 'Tis of Thee” near the end.

Happy Study

